PERKALATE / RESTAURANTS

# The Off Hours Playbook: Fill Slow Shifts Without Discounting Your Menu

A step by step playbook for restaurants and bars to fill slow shifts with targeted rewards instead of blanket discounts.

Slow shifts are fixable, but not with a sign in the window. The venues that fill their quiet hours well treat it like any other part of operations: they pick a target, design an offer for it, and check whether it worked. Here's a playbook you can run this month.

## Step one: map the hours you actually want to fill

Pull two to four weeks of sales by hour and day from your point of sale. Mark every window that runs below half your usual covers. You'll probably find two or three patterns, not twenty. Pick one to start, such as weekdays from three to five, or Monday and Tuesday after eight. One window is easier to staff, easier to explain, and easier to measure.

## Step two: choose an offer that's cheap to serve and easy to love

The best off hours reward is something with a low cost to you and a high perceived value to the guest. A house drink, a snack from the bar menu, an upgrade on a coffee, a dessert with a main. Avoid percentage discounts on the whole bill. They're expensive, they're hard to explain to staff, and they say "we're cheaper now" instead of "come try us."

Keep the rules short enough to fit on a coaster: what it is, when it works, and that it's one per guest.

## Step three: target people, don't broadcast

Stop discounting to everyone. A reward shown to your existing regulars mostly buys visits you already had. The goal is the person who is nearby, fits your crowd, and hasn't been in yet. That might mean members of a gym down the street, guests at a nearby hotel, or customers of a brand whose taste overlaps with yours. The narrower the audience, the more each redemption is worth.

## Step four: put the claim where the decision happens

People decide in the moment. Make the reward visible and claimable right there: a table tent at the bar, a coaster, a sticker on the host stand or the front window, a line your staff can say without thinking. If claiming takes an app download and an account, most people won't bother. A quick scan and a confirmation is the bar to aim for.

Brief your team in one sentence. "If someone shows you this between three and five, the drink is on the house." Staff who understand the offer will mention it. Staff who don't will avoid it.

## Step five: design for the second visit

The first visit is the introduction. The second visit is the business. Most first time guests never return, often because nothing gave them a reason to. Build the second visit into the plan from day one: a follow up reward for a return within a few weeks, a personal welcome back, a reason to try the dinner menu after an afternoon drink. If you only measure the first visit, you'll undervalue every promotion you run.

## Step six: let a partner fund it

Here's where the economics change. You don't have to be the one paying for the reward. Brands that want to reach your neighborhood's customers will often fund a reward for them at a venue that fits their audience. A spirits brand funds a cocktail. A coffee roaster funds a pour over. A local business funds a snack for its own members. You provide the room and the hospitality, and they cover the cost.

When you approach partners, bring three things: the hours you want to fill, a short description of who you'd like in the room, and how you'll report back on the results.

## Mistakes to avoid

1. Running three offers at once, so nobody knows which one worked.
2. Changing the offer every week before it has time to settle.
3. Hiding the reward behind a complicated sign up.
4. Measuring only total covers instead of claims and redemptions.

## Plan a pilot

Choose one audience, one reward and one result to measure. Set the budget and eligibility rules before launch. Tell participants which information you need and share results in aggregate where possible.